

Chapter 3

A Course in Miracles: The True History

A Book With Four Versions

Most readers of A Course in Miracles do not know there are multiple versions of the book. They read the edition published by the Foundation for Inner Peace, the version found in bookstores, the version studied in groups, the version that has shaped popular understanding of the Course for decades.

But this is the fourth version, not the first.

Four distinct versions of the Course exist, each further from the original dictation than the last:

1. **The Shorthand Notes.** Helen Schucman's original handwritten notebooks, the raw dictation as she first received it.
2. **The Urtext.** Helen and Bill Thetford's first typed transcription, lightly edited with dictated corrections incorporated and most personal material removed. This is the closest typed copy to the original dictation.
3. **The Hugh Lynn Cayce version (HLC).** A substantially abridged second edit by Helen and Bill, named for Hugh Lynn Cayce (son of Edgar Cayce), to whom a copy was given. This version removed approximately 38,000 words from the Urtext.

4. The Foundation for Inner Peace (FIP) version. A further reworking of the HLC, prepared by Helen Schucman and Ken Wapnick in 1973-74. This removed an additional 10,000 words and extensively rewrote portions of the early chapters. Published in 1975-76, this became the standard edition.

In total, roughly 48,000 words were removed between the Urtext and the FIP edition. Understanding this history matters. For readers seeking to integrate the Course with the Urantia Book, the earlier versions preserve context that creates a far more natural bridge between the two revelations.

This chapter tells the story of how the Course came to us, and what was lost along the way.

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Helen and Bill: The Original Collaboration

In 1965, Helen Schucman began hearing an inner voice. She was a research psychologist at Columbia University, working alongside her colleague Bill Thetford. Neither was particularly religious. Both were skeptical of mystical experiences.

Yet the voice persisted. It identified itself as Jesus. And it asked Helen to take dictation.

The process that followed lasted seven years. Helen would hear nonverbal communication, ideas impressed upon her mind, and translate them into shorthand notes. The voice did not speak in audible words; Helen had to find the language herself. She was fully conscious throughout, never in trance. The process was laborious, requiring intense concentration.

Each evening, Helen would review her shorthand and transcribe it into longhand. Then Bill would type Helen's handwritten pages. Together they discussed the material, questioned it, and, with the voice's explicit permission, edited it.

This collaboration between Helen, Bill, and Jesus produced the raw material from which all four versions descend.

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The Editing Process

The Urtext was not the raw dictation. Helen translated nonverbal impressions into shorthand notes, then reviewed and transcribed them into longhand. Bill typed her handwritten pages. Together they discussed the material, questioned it, and, with the voice's explicit permission, shaped it into readable form.

This first typed version, the Urtext, incorporated dictated corrections and removed most of the personal communications between Jesus, Helen, and Bill that were never meant for publication. But the teaching itself was left largely intact. The Urtext contains approximately 337,000 words and represents the most complete and accurate typed copy of the original dictation available.

This creates an important distinction. The Urtext is not "Jesus' literal words" in the way some imagine. Helen translated nonverbal impressions into language. She and Bill then shaped that language into readable form. The result is Jesus' message filtered through human minds and human decisions.

This is the nature of personal revelation. Unlike the Urantia Book (where a sleeping subject transmitted material without conscious filtering), the Course passed through Helen's vocabulary, her conceptual framework, her editorial judgment. Jesus worked within these limitations rather than overriding them.

Helen and Bill then produced a second edit, substantially abridging the Urtext. This version, known as the Hugh Lynn Cayce version (HLC), reduced the text by roughly 38,000 words. A copy was given to the Edgar Cayce library at the Association for Research and Enlightenment. The HLC is the basis for what is sometimes called the "JCIM" or "Original" edition published by the Course in Miracles Society.

After the HLC was completed, Bill disengaged from further editing. His work was done.

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The Second Round of Editing

Ken Wapnick then convinced Helen that the text needed further editing. Unlike the original collaboration, where Helen and Bill had edited with Jesus' permission and guidance, this new round of editing was Wapnick's initiative. Helen, by some accounts exhausted and worn down from the years of scribing, went along with the process.

Working from the already-abridged HLC, Wapnick and Helen removed an additional 10,000 words. Significant portions of the first five chapters were cut or rewritten. The introduction was rewritten. Material that connected the Course to broader spiritual concepts was trimmed. The result was a leaner, more focused text, but also a text that had lost important context at two stages of editing. Jesus himself had warned against this, saying that "some of the later parts of the course rest too heavily on these earlier sections not to require their study." These were the very sections most heavily edited by the Foundation for Inner Peace.

In 1975-76, the Foundation for Inner Peace published what became the standard edition. This is what most people mean when they say "A Course in Miracles." For decades, it was the only version widely available. The earlier versions existed outside the control of those preparing the published edition, waiting to be rediscovered.

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The Discovery of the Earlier Versions

In 2000, a copyright lawsuit changed everything.

The Foundation for Inner Peace sued Endeavor Academy for publishing Course material without permission. During the legal proceedings, researchers discovered that Helen's original shorthand notebooks had been deposited in the Library of Congress. The copyright claim required establishing what the original text actually was.

What emerged were three earlier versions of the Course, dramatically different from the published edition, especially in the first eight chapters. Far from being "virtually unchanged" as the Foundation had long claimed, the earlier manuscripts contained a vast amount of previously unpublished material. They revealed that in the later editing, much that was not entirely removed had been extensively rewritten, sometimes almost beyond recognition.

The lawsuit ultimately resulted in much of the Course entering the public domain. More importantly, it made the earlier texts accessible to anyone who wanted to study them. For the first time, readers could trace the full editing history from the original Shorthand Notes through the Urtext and HLC to the published FIP edition.

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Earlier Versions vs. FIP: Why It Matters

In the original text of A Course in Miracles, Jesus makes a direct statement about the importance of the early chapters:

"This is a course in mind training. All learning involves attention and study at some level. Some of the later parts of the course rest too heavily on these earlier sections not to require their study. You will also need them for preparation. Without this, you may become much too fearful when the unexpected does occur to make constructive use of it. However, as you study these earlier sections, you will begin to see some of their implications, which will be amplified considerably later on."

These earlier sections, the very ones Jesus said were necessary for understanding the later parts of the Course, were heavily edited by the Foundation for Inner Peace.

This creates a problem. Readers of the FIP edition are missing material that Jesus said they would need. Without this preparation, the later teachings can be misunderstood.

One critical example: the published version suggests, in ways the earlier versions do not, that the ego created material reality. This idea creates an apparent conflict with the Urantia Book, which clearly teaches that God created the material universe through his creative agencies.

The earlier versions are clearer: the ego did not create the physical world. The ego creates our *perception* of the world, the fearful, separated, conflicted way we experience reality. But the material cosmos itself is God's creation, distorted by our perception, not fabricated by our delusion.

The Urtext defines this in the early chapters that were most heavily edited:

"The world, in the original connotation of the term, included both the proper creation of man by God and the proper creation by man in his right mind. The latter required the endowment of man by God with free will because all loving creation is freely given. Nothing in these statements implies any sort of level involvement or in fact anything except one continuous line of creation in which all aspects are of the same order." (HLC, Chapter 2)

One continuous line of creation. The world, properly understood, is not the ego's product. It is God's creation extended through man's free will. The problem is not the world. The problem is what happened next: "The ego made the world as IT perceives it." Not the world itself, but a fearful interpretation laid over it.

And Jesus warns against confusing the two:

"The body is merely a fact in human experience. Its abilities can be and frequently are over-evaluated. However, it is almost impossible to deny

its existence. Those who do so are engaging in a particularly unworthy form of denial." (HLC, Chapter 2, Tx 2.56)

The body is a fact. The physical world is a fact. Denying their existence is not spiritual insight; it is unworthy denial. The mind can miscreate, but miscreation is perceptual, not cosmological. The ego builds a house of fear on a foundation God laid in love. The foundation is real. The fear is not.

The published FIP version, missing the earlier context Jesus said was necessary, obscures this distinction.

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Which Version to Read

Throughout this book, Course quotations are drawn from the Hugh Lynn Cayce (HLC) version unless otherwise noted. This is the version published by the Course in Miracles Society as the "JCIM" or "Original" edition. Where quotations are drawn from the Urtext, they will be cited as such.

The earlier versions of the Course are available online and can be compared line by line with the published FIP edition. Readers who have studied the Foundation for Inner Peace version will find the core teachings familiar, but the additional context illuminating.

For those integrating the Course with the Urantia Book, the earlier versions are essential. They preserve Jesus' teaching in its fuller form, before editorial decisions removed material that connects the Course to broader cosmological truth.

Helen Schucman spent seven years taking down what she heard. Bill Thetford spent those same years typing, questioning, and collaborating. Together with Jesus, they produced something remarkable: a personal revelation from the Creator Son to a quarantined world.

That original work deserves to be read.

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A Word to Urantia Book Readers

When Course in Miracles students say the world is an illusion, Urantia Book readers often recoil. How can you call a universe teeming with billions of inhabited worlds, celestial administrators, and evolutionary purpose an illusion? But before dismissing the Course, consider what the Urantia Book says. Jesus "frequently alluded to the natural as 'the unreal and fleeting shadow of spirit realities'" (UB 151:3.3). The Urantia Book's own celestial authors state plainly: "To spirit beings the material world is almost entirely unreal, being merely a shadow of the substance of spirit realities" (UB 44:0.15). They call evil "really nonexistent" (UB 130:1.6) and describe it as "cosmic unreality" (UB 2:3.5). They say "the eternal real is the good of the universe and not the time illusions of space evil" (UB 102:3.15). They tell you that much of your material experience "will perish with the material brain" as "onetime scaffolding" (UB 112:5.22). And they assure you that "nothing of survival value is ever lost in all the wide universe" (UB 109:3.2). Now read the Course's opening lines again: "Nothing real can be threatened. Nothing unreal exists." That is not a foreign teaching. That is the eternal perspective, stated with the brevity of one who lives there. The Course is not denying your universe. It is speaking from the vantage point the Urantia Book describes: the view from eternity, where time is a moving image, space is a fleeting shadow, and everything of genuine worth is already safe in the hands of God. The discomfort you feel is not a contradiction between the books. It is the paradox the Urantia Book itself names: "The Human Paradox" (UB 111:6), the tension of a creature who lives in time but is indwelt by eternity. The Course did not invent that tension. It is trying to help you resolve it.